

Chapter 126 - Memories

"No, it's too dangerous!" This time Chu Qingqiu wouldn't listen to her, turning her head away to avoid her kiss.

"It's all dangerous - what difference does it make whether you go or I go?"

"You're injured!" Chu Qingqiu frowned and scolded. She wanted to return Jiang Li to her, but Ning Fuyi suddenly pushed her away and let herself fall freely, disappearing into the thick miasma in the blink of an eye.

Her movements were too fast. Chu Qingqiu could only hold Jiang Li tightly. When she looked down again, that figure was already gone, with only thick black mist rolling like ink below her feet.

"Ning Fuyi!" Chu Qingqiu was so angry her cheeks burned, but the thick miasma had already spread to the cave entrance. The dark invasive feeling quickly enveloped her.

Chu Qingqiu glanced at the unconscious Jiang Li in her arms and had no choice but to lean back, transforming into a white light and swiftly flying out of the cave.

Outside the cave, yellow sand filled the air. The sky was covered by dark clouds, and the cracked earth and towering rocky mountains all around were tinged with a lifeless gray, as if the end of days was approaching.

Several red-backed insects hurriedly crawled across the ground and drilled into cracks, as if avoiding something.

Chu Qingqiu crashed down into the group of people, handing Jiang Li to Liu Wenzhu who was sitting paralyzed on the ground.

Liu Wenzhu hastily caught Jiang Li, her eyes looking hopefully behind Chu Qingqiu. When she found no one there, her wrists went weak: "Where's Yiyi?"

"Sister Ning..." Baili Shiqi, who had been sitting listlessly to one side, also rolled over and crawled up, worried.

"Went to get Sect Leader Tang." Chu Qingqiu appeared calm, but her palms were already so sweaty she could barely grip the White Bone. She turned to go back, but Jiuying, who was lying exhausted on the side, bit onto her hem.

"Where are you going again?" Jiuying mumbled with her mouth full.

Without a word, Chu Qingqiu raised the White Bone and chopped the hem that Jiuying was biting into two pieces, the cloth slowly falling: "To get her."

"Jiuying, if we haven't come up after one incense stick's time, you must completely seal this cave entrance and never let that fortress see daylight again." Chu Qingqiu said.

"I..."

Before anyone could respond, Chu Qingqiu's body had already transformed into flowing light, cutting through the endless yellow sand, then being covered by falling dust.

Inside the fortress.

The speed at which miasma invaded the body was like locusts crossing a field, quickly able to devour one's soul. Ning Fuyi used magical power to condense a barrier around herself, buying some time.

The miasma was so thick that eyes were completely useless, and hearing was also rendered ineffective by the sounds of the ghostly regions. For a moment, her vision was completely sealed, and she could only grope forward limb by limb.

Ning Fuyi moved toward the Infinite Ghost Fire based on her earlier memory. Fortunately, the heat hadn't dissipated, and she quickly sensed the scalding smoke, so she quickened her pace forward.

Foul odors continuously invaded her nose. The ground was entirely paved with snake corpses, soft and sticky underfoot with a texture that made one's skin crawl. Ning Fuyi reached out to move forward slowly when suddenly she hissed and pulled her hand back to her chest.

Although her fingertips were burned, she was immediately overjoyed because what she had just touched was the furnace for refining Infinite Ghost Fire. She leaped up and landed steadily on the edge of the furnace in the thick miasma.

Water vapor steamed around her. The flames had already been extinguished, leaving only moisture and thick miasma in the furnace. Ning Fuyi hurriedly looked around and finally found Tang Wenshu's body on the furnace steps.

He was soaked through, obviously still fighting the fire at the last moment before collapsing from exhaustion. His pulse was now weak, his mouth and nose sealed shut, already filled with miasma in his lungs.

Ning Fuyi slapped away the sand spirits gnawing on him, grabbed his arm and pulled him onto her back, stepped on her Emei thorns, and flew toward the sky while holding her breath.

The crack that Chu Qingqiu had smashed overhead revealed a faint glow, looking like a narrow moon covered by thick miasma from afar. As that narrow moon drew closer and closer, Ning Fuyi's tense heart increasingly relaxed.

Just then, Ning Fuyi's expression suddenly changed.

A massive black shadow appeared behind her. The buzzing of sand spirits in her ears turned into an eerie song, mixed with bells and drums that struck her heart and drove it into the ground.

Sticky snake tails had somehow wrapped around her ankles, like countless insects and ants surging over her body. Fear made her hair stand on end.

"Emei thorns." Ning Fuyi suddenly said. No one could hear her voice, but the Emei thorns glowed faintly in her palm, spinning and growing larger, supporting Tang Wenshu's body as they headed toward the narrow moon alone.

She was left empty-handed, condensing pink lightning in both palms. The light surrounded and surged around her like meteors, dispelling some of the thick miasma.

The black shadow before her had a massive body, looking down at her with two hollow eyes. Where hair should have been on its head, there were writhing snakes floating like water plants.

It matched the shape in the totems exactly - it was the god worshipped in the totems, and also the spirit guardian of this ancient land.

"You should know who destroyed this place." Ning Fuyi's wrists trembled slightly. That drumming was destroying her mind, and blocking her ears was useless.

"Invading my land, unforgivable sin." An ancient voice like breathing echoed through her mind. Ning Fuyi's consciousness was almost shattered by this voice. Green vitality withered in an instant before her eyes, lush trees swaying in fierce winds, almost uprooted.

No, Ning Fuyi was actually afraid. She thought she hadn't felt the taste of fear for a long, long time, but now this fear was drowning her.

What she feared wasn't death itself.

"Don't." Ning Fuyi said.

"Must be executed." The ancient voice rang out again.

Fierce winds immediately rose all around, and all the miasma rushed toward her alone. Ning Fuyi cried out in pain toward the sky while condensing all her immortal power in her palms. Pink light transformed into two beams of light, surging fiercely toward the black shadow.

In that instant, the fortress that had stood for ten thousand years completely collapsed. Walls and bricks turned to dust, completely burying everything in this land. The black shadow's body was pierced with two large holes, and the snakes on its head that shouldn't have been able to cry out let out a collective hissing.

At the same time, miasma penetrated her surrounding barrier, stabbing into her lungs and limbs like blades. Ning Fuyi instantly lost consciousness from the pain, then quickly woke up again.

Good thing it wasn't Chu Qingqiu - this thought suddenly flashed through her mind.

The ancient song hadn't stopped yet. Miasma had already filled her entire body, and would soon burst through her body at the black shadow's command, exploding her into a blood mist.

Ning Fuyi closed her eyes, but just then another figure rushed out of the fog. With flexible limbs and curled black hair, she grabbed the black shadow and pressed it down toward the earth's core, dust flying everywhere.

Ning Fuyi's body also fell accordingly, but soon a pure white silk ribbon hung down from the sky, gently wrapping around her waist.

She was quickly drawn into the fragrant embrace of a woman who was calling her name in panic. Although Ning Fuyi was weak all over, she still raised her hand to tightly embrace her waist.

"It hurts so much, Chu Qingqiu." She buried her face in the woman's shoulder and said softly.

The wind outside was very yellow, but compared to underground it was still bright and clean. Ning Fuyi was placed under rocks in a half-conscious state. Jiuying and the others were desperately sealing the cave entrance, while Liu Wenzhu wrapped her in clothes with tears, trembling as she said: "Yiyi, what's wrong with you?"

Ning Fuyi's face was now pale as paper, but her lips were somewhat black, with faint black qi emerging from her mouth and nose, causing her to tremble all over from pain.

What caused her pain wasn't the miasma, but her head, as if something wanted to break through her skull, madly hammering at her head bones.

"She's full of miasma!" Baili Shiqi cried until her eyes were red and swollen. She rummaged through her pouch and took out life-saving pills to stuff into Ning Fuyi's mouth, then joined the others in casting spells to draw it out.

By this time the cave had been sealed. Jiuying and Hua Feihua placed the unconscious Tang Wenshu, Jiang Li, and Qiu Yi to one side, then immediately came over to help.

Jiuying hadn't transformed into human form yet. Her massive body couldn't get close, so she could only stay far away to shield them from the sand and wind while calling to her through their contract in her mind.

"Ning Fuyi, Ning Fuyi, Ning Fuyi..."

"I can hear you, so noisy." Ning Fuyi couldn't speak with her mouth, so she replied in her mind.

But just thinking this one sentence made her head feel like it was splitting into four or five pieces, so she frowned and groaned.

Even Hua Feihua, who wasn't very familiar with them, had reddened eyes, revealing an unbearable expression. He raised his hand to join the others, and soon there was very little miasma left in her body.

"The miasma has been expelled, so why is there still black qi surrounding her?" Liu Wenzhu tremblingly touched her forehead, feeling it ice cold.

"Chu Qingqiu." Ning Fuyi suddenly spoke, her voice weak but still audible. Everyone was startled and turned to look at Chu Qingqiu who was sitting cross-legged with a stern expression.

Her face was silent and calm at the moment, but her palms were already full of sweat, and if one looked closely, even her fingertips were trembling.

She suddenly half-knelt forward and gathered the person into her embrace. Ning Fuyi naturally hugged her waist tightly, nestling in her arms.

Their posture was extremely intimate, making everyone around them stunned. Except for Jiuying, they all felt a strange sense of confusion.

Hua Feihua and Liu Wenzhu looked away after making eye contact, while Baili Shiqi's eyes widened, her cheeks flushed, and her eyes became increasingly unfocused.

"I said I would go but you wouldn't listen. How is it now?" Chu Qingqiu held her cold shoulders and back tightly, moisture wetting her eyelashes.

"Very good." Ning Fuyi said.

Chu Qingqiu closed her eyes and pinched her ear.

The two of them didn't care about anything anymore, their actions completely unlike the interaction between an elder and junior. All who saw them were speechless.

Chu Qingqiu's voice was moist and muffled as she spoke in her ear: "I'm not some delicate flower - why do you always have to block everything in front of me?"

"If you wither, I'll have nothing left to hope for." Ning Fuyi's voice was weak.

She suddenly stiffened, a strange feeling penetrating her heart. At the same time, Liu Wenzhu's scream reached her ears. Ning Fuyi had no time to react and hurriedly pushed Chu Qingqiu away with one palm, staggering to her feet and backing away repeatedly.

"Yiyi..." Liu Wenzhu ran toward her but was pulled back by Hua Feihua: "Be careful!"

Waves of black qi drifted before Ning Fuyi's eyes. She initially thought it was undispersed thick miasma, but now she dimly realized that the source of the black qi was actually herself.

Familiar power was surging all around her body. Her eyes gradually turned red, and a violent feeling was tearing at her heart, trying to occupy her consciousness.

The impact of the miasma just now had almost collapsed the seal on her demonic root.

"Not good... Ning Fuyi!" Chu Qingqiu panicked, quickly stepping forward, but was blocked by a bolt of lightning that Ning Fuyi struck down with her hand.

"Don't come over!" Ning Fuyi said sternly. Malicious energy was now swirling in her phoenix eyes, her black clothes billowing with demonic energy, stirring up wind and sand like a ghost.

"None of you come over." She said hoarsely. "Get lost quickly!"

"She's about to become a demon - don't go!" Hua Feihua held Liu Wenzhu with one hand and grabbed Baili Shiqi with the other, stopping the two panicked women. However, he could stop people but not beasts. Jiuying had already pounced over, trying to suppress the demonic energy on Ning Fuyi.

Fire and demonic energy merged in the dust, with Jiuying's beast roars coming from time to time. One person and one beast rolled to the ground, causing mountains and rivers to shake, almost waking the other three who were unconscious.

"This is..." Tang Wenshu covered his heart and coughed, speaking in shock.

"Qilin Jiuying¹!" For the first time, Ning Fuyi clearly invoked the master-servant restraint of their contract, binding Jiuying firmly to the ground. The beast roars gradually turned into a woman's shouts.

Jiuying transformed into human form and collapsed, her lotus-white shoulders and back covered in yellow sand. She was half angry and half in pain: "Ning Fuyi, you dare to bind me!"

"I'm sorry." Ning Fuyi's eyes moistened as she kept backing away. "I'm sorry..."

Feather-like ice frost attacked. Ning Fuyi quickly cut off Chu Qingqiu's path, then malicious energy covered her eyes again. She suddenly raised both arms, and thunderous lightning, countless bolts of electricity flew down, forming a large net around herself, blocking others out while also trapping herself.

She fell to the ground in pain, hearing Chu Qingqiu's panicked crying for the first time. The electric net trembled because of Chu Qingqiu but couldn't be shaken.

Her vision went black for a moment, then pure white emerged.

As demonic energy occupied her body, it seemed to also break through some barrier. Broken fragments drew themselves on that pure white space, finally forming immersive scenes.

She tremblingly raised her hand, trying to touch those vivid faces in the scenes.

Footnotes:

1. **Qilin Jiuying (麒麟嬰)** - This is Jiuying's full name/title, combining "Qilin" (the mythical creature she can transform into) with "Jiuying" (Nine Infants, referencing the ancient mythological creature).